London Metropolitan University

Appropriation and Hybridity of Taiwanese Literati Painting and American Abstract Expressionism (1949 – 2007)

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4.1.1 Mark Tobey

It is strikingly similar in the objectives and methods between Oriental painting and certain key modern artistic movements that we can suppose that these radical Western artistic developments have, to some extent at least, been inspired by Far Eastern art and thought. The parallels are plenty but it was notably in the work of Mark Tobey[238] (1890-1976) that "Oriental art first struck a responsive chord in an American painter."[239]

According to Sullivan, Mark Tobey's defining moment appeared in "one autumn evening in 1935 at Dartington Hall, in the year following his fruitful visit to the Far East, and though his first exercise in 'white writing' looked to him like Broadway, it was unconsciously inspired by his experience of studying calligraphy in Japan."[240] His influences had been built up over the years from his first encounter of Japanese prints in Seattle in 1923, and met the Chinese artist Teng Kuei[241] (1900-1980). Tobey was first taught how to execute the Chinese brush and ink by Teng Kuei, and eventually stayed with him in Shanghai ten years later.[242] In addition, Tobey took a

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[238] Mark Tobey is a painter, poet and composer. He was born in Centerville, Wisconsin in 1890. In 1906, he was trained watercolor and oil painting at the Art Institute in Chicago. In 1918 Mark Tobey shifted to Bahaism which is Persian belief. From 1922 to 1925 he acquired a job as an art teacher at the Cornish School in Seattle. Moreover, his first solo exhibition took place in Chicago in 1928. He then moved to England and teaches at the Dartington Hall School in Devonshire from 1930 to 1937.

[239] Michael Sullivan, *The Meeting of Eastern and Western Art: Revised and Expanded Edition*, (Berkeley: University of California Press Ltd., 1997), 263

[240] Michael Sullivan, *The Meeting of Eastern and Western Art: Revised and Expanded Edition*, (Berkeley: University of California Press Ltd., 1997), 257-8

[241] Teng Kuei (滕圭) went to America to learn sculpture at Washington of University in 1923, and he then taught at this university after graduation in 1927. He also held exhibitions in some cities during the period while living in America. After 1931 he came back to China and taught in the Yan Jing University, simultaneously he also established the *Bai Ye Sculpture and Painting School* (白也雕塑繪畫館) in Shanghai, China.

[242] Willian C. Seitz, *Mark Tobey*, (New York: The Museum of Modern Art, 1962), 49

Without doubt, the Chinese artist Teng Kuei played a crucial role in Tobey's development in his formative years, teaching him calligraphy and Ink-wash painting techniques, as well as providing insight into the various Chinese artistic concepts and aesthetic theories. This new knowledge of Oriental art and thinking was very different from his Occidental cultural background and conditioning, having a large impact on him. Tobey recalled that, "I have just had my first lesson in Chinese brush from my friend and artist Teng Kuei. The tree is no more a solid in the earth, breaking into lesser solids bathed in chiaroscuro."[247]

In terms of the underlying influence of calligraphic manner in Tobey's artistic production, he once claimed that,

> "I knew when in Japan and China as I struggled with their sumi ink and brush in an attempt to understand their calligraphy... But it was there that I got what I call the calligraphic impulse to carry my work on into some new dimensions...With this method I found I could paint the frenetic rhythms of the modern city, the interweaving of lights and the stream of people who entangled in the meshes of this net[248]"

[247] Willian C. Seitz, *Mark Tobey*, (New York: The Museum of Modern Art, 1962), 47
[248] Willian C. Seitz, *Mark Tobey*, (New York: The Museum of Modern Art, 1962), 51